

GTD

Getting Things Done

Format: ~25-minute introduction

Audience goal: Understand the GTD mindset, see why it reduces mental load, and leave with a small experiment they can try themselves.

Core message: *GTD is not about doing more. It is about getting things out of your head, defining what “done” means, deciding the next physical action, and trusting a system enough to focus on what matters now.*



0. What are we even talking about?

GTD = Getting Things Done

A practical productivity method for getting all the unfinished stuff out of your head and into a trusted system.

It helps you answer three questions:

1. What needs attention?
2. What does “done” mean?
3. What is the next visible action?

The goal is not to work faster. The goal is to reduce mental clutter so you can focus on what matters now.



1. Why do we need GTD?

The brain is good at thinking, solving problems and making decisions.

It is not a great task-management system.

GTD moves unfinished commitments into a trusted external system.

Your head is for having ideas, not for holding them.



2. The GTD workflow

Capture → Clarify → Organize → Reflect → Engage

1. 📥 **Capture** — collect what has your attention.
 - idea for the presentation, follow-up email, invoice
2. 🧭 **Clarify** — decide what it means and whether action is required.
 - send follow-up email = task; receipt = reference; improve workflow = vague
3. 📁 **Organize** — put the result where it belongs.
 - calendar, next action, waiting for, reference
4. 🔄 **Reflect** — regularly review and refresh the system.
 - did I already reply? is this still relevant?
5. ⚡ **Engage** — choose what to do based on the current situation.
 - 10 minutes before lunch? email. evening? book appointment.

Capture gives you completeness. Clarify gives you clarity. Review gives you trust.



3. Capture — build a real Inbox

The Inbox is a collection point, not your final task list.

Anything can enter it: a task, idea, question, request, reminder or something you suddenly remember.



When something has your attention, give it somewhere to go.

Let's do it live

Take one or two things from your inbox and turn them into a GTD example together.

Pick an item, ask: what is it, is action required, what does done look like, and what is the next visible action?

This is where GTD becomes practical: vague thoughts turn into clear, actionable work.

4. Clarify — what does it mean?

For each captured item ask:

1. What is it?

- Example: "Book a flight" is not the same as "travel to Berlin."

2. Is action required?

- Example: "Remember to ask Jan about the budget" is a task; "Budget notes from last month" is reference.

3. What would "done" look like?

- Example: "Prepare the presentation" becomes "slides drafted and sent for review."

4. What is the next physical, visible action?

- Example: "Clean the garage" becomes "Put the bins outside and sort the boxes."

If no action is required, it may be trash, reference, Waiting For or Someday / Maybe.

If an action took less than 2 minutes, just execute it.

The goal is to remove vague thinking and replace it with clear next steps.



5. Next Action — make it executable

A **Next Action** is the very next physical, visible step that moves something forward.

It should be small enough to start without more thinking, and concrete enough to put on a list.

Not “Fix the house.”

Instead: “**Measure the wall before ordering the shelf.**”

In GTD terms, your Next Actions are not just a vague to-do list. They are a managed collection of actionable items, typically grouped by context, priority and time required.

Examples:

- Draft the first version of the GTD presentation — 60 minutes
- Write a short update about the home renovation plan — 120 minutes

A good Next Action is clear enough that you can start immediately.



6. Projects — manage outcomes

In GTD, a **project** is an outcome that requires more than one action.

Examples:

- Prepare the GTD presentation
- Organize the office
- Plan the family holiday

The important question is:

What outcome do I want, and what is the next action?

Every active project should have at least one clearly defined Next Action.

7. Give every commitment a home



Calendar — things that need to happen at a specific date/time.



Waiting For — things that depend on another person or event.



Someday / Maybe — possibilities that are not commitments yet.



Reference — useful information that requires no action.

Not everything is a task. But everything should have a place.





8. Weekly Review — build trust

Review the Inbox, Calendar, Waiting For, active projects and Someday / Maybe.

Make sure every active project has a Next Action.

Close, delete or update stale items.

The Weekly Review is the maintenance routine that keeps the system credible.

9. Choosing what to do

GTD does not prescribe one priority list. It helps you choose by looking at:

- **Context** — where am I and what tools do I have?
- **Time** — how much time is available?
- **Energy** — what can I realistically handle?
- **Priority** — what matters most now?

Example:

"I woke up early and I have one extra hour today. Give me a few Next Actions that are quick wins, and focus on actions that can be completed in a short time instead of filling the full hour with one big task."

This is exactly where GTD helps: it turns a vague feeling of "I should do something useful" into a small set of practical choices.

GTD gives you a trustworthy set of options, not just a long to-do list.



10. My personal example — GTD + ChatGPT + Github

I use ChatGPT as the interface to parts of my GTD system at Github.

- `/inbox` — capture quickly
- `/list` — list the next actions and see executable work
- `/done #6 30 minutes` — close an item, record the time, and store it in `done.md`
- `/del #16` — remove an item

The important part is not the commands. It is the reduction of friction between “**I just remembered something**” and “**It is safely in my system.**”

I use it as my external brain: it stores the tasks, frees up space in my head, and gives me more energy for creativity instead of mental bookkeeping.





11. My other trick — recurring tasks

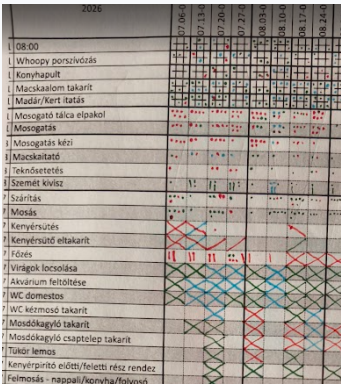
For recurring maintenance I use a simple **daily / weekly table**.

It removes the recurring question:

“What was I supposed to do today?”

A predefined routine means I do not have to keep rediscovering the same decisions.

Don't spend decision-making energy on decisions you can make once.



12. A GTD + ChatGPT workflow in practice

1. During the day: Capture.

- example: "I have an idea for my GTD presentation" → send it to `/inbox` before it slips away.

2. Processing: Clarify + Organize.

- example: "Improve my GTD presentation" → Next Action: rewrite slide 12; context: computer; time: 10 minutes.

3. During work: Choose actions that fit your context, available time, energy and priority.

- example: "I have 20 minutes and my phone" → ask ChatGPT for a few suitable phone actions.

4. After completion: Close the loop and record the actual time spent.

- example: finish the call after 30 minutes → use `/done #6 30 minutes` to mark it complete and record the actual time spent.

5. Weekly: Reflect and restore trust.

- example: review the Inbox, projects, Waiting For and Someday / Maybe, then update the next actions.



13. From the audience homework to a working system

Bring back the 10–15 things you captured yesterday.

Pick one and ask:

1. What is it?
2. Does it require action?
3. What does done look like?
4. What is the next physical action?
5. Where should it live?

Example: “Learn Spanish”

Desired outcome: Be able to talk at a basic level on my next vacation in Spain

Next Action: **search online for a suitable beginner course and sign up for it.**

Where should it live: Its a project with multiple actions



14. Why GTD can help beyond productivity

The deeper benefit is **mental clarity**:

- fewer unfinished commitments in your head;
- less repeated re-deciding;
- easier starts;
- better focus;
- more intentional choices.



The goal is to be fully engaged with what you are doing, while knowing that other commitments are safely captured and managed.

15. Attention and digital distractions

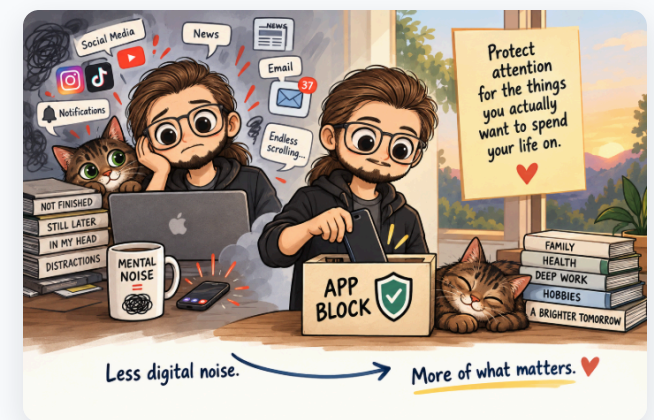
GTD is not a cure for distraction, but it can remove mental noise caused by unfinished business.

Protect attention for the things you actually want to spend your life on.

A trusted external system and deliberate attention management complement each other.

Side note:

If digital noise is still getting in the way, app blockers can add another layer of protection. For example, **AppBlock** lets you set daily usage limits, time windows and other rules to reduce doom-scrolling or late nights on Facebook. That makes it easier to stay focused and be present with your family during a movie instead of reaching for your phone every few minutes.



16. The smallest GTD experiment — try this tomorrow

1. Create **one Inbox**.
2. Capture what keeps popping into your head.
3. Process it regularly.
4. Turn commitments into **Next Actions**.
5. Review once a week.

Start small. The system can grow when the simple version is already useful.



17. Tips for success

- Keep it simple.
- Be consistent, not perfect.
- Use tools that work for you.
- Focus on Next Actions.
- Review regularly.
- Celebrate progress.



18. A real-life example — GTD at GitHub

I use GitHub as part of my external system: ideas, issues and follow-up work are captured where they can be reviewed and turned into clear Next Actions.

Files

main

Go to file

Projects

Someday

00_Inbox.md

00_SISInbox.md

01_NextActions.md

02_Routines.md

10_WeeklyReview.md

80_WaitingFor.md

85_Calendar.md

99_Done.md

AGENTS.md

AGENT_INSTRUCTIONS.md

Commands.md

README.md

Gtd-ai / 01_NextActions.md

Preview Code Blame 50 lines (43 loc) · 3.81 KB

Next Actions

Secondary sorting: when priorities are equal, the shorter task is placed first.



Small steps
Big progress!

#		Next Action	Time	Priority	Label	Label / restriction
2	💡	Repair the office lamp.	45 min	P3	Office	
3	🖨️	Replace the printer cartridges.	30 min	P4	Office	Only on weekdays
5	🌱	Put the indoor plant into a pot.	30 min	P4	Home	
7	💡	Repair the kitchen lamp.	60 min	P4	DIY	
10	🛋️	Move the thermometer next to the sofa.	20 min	P5	Home	
12	💡	Repair the small living-room lamp.	30 min	P5	DIY	
18	🔒	Log in to nmbrs and check exactly whether my vacation days have been entered; if so, notify HR so they can approve them.	30 min	P5	Administration	
13	🛋️	Put Plexi next to the sofa so that the air conditioner doesn't blow onto the flowers.	45 min	P5	DIY	
45	🪑	Organize the stuff behind the office chair.	45 min	P5	Organizing	
46	🧰	Declutter the toolbox.	45 min	P5	Organizing	

(and yes, there are more than this)

19. References

- GTD website: <https://gettingthingsdone.com/getting-things-done-the-art-of-stress-free-productivity/>
- Book: Getting Things Done by David Allen: <https://www.amazon.com/Getting-Things-Done-Stress-Free-Productivity/dp/0143126563>

These are the core sources behind the GTD model and the practical thinking behind the examples in this session.



20. Q&A

Questions? Ideas? Let's discuss what could work for you.

21. Key takeaways

- 🧠 Clear your mind
- 🎯 Focus on what matters
- ⚡ Turn ideas into action
- 🌿 Reduce stress
- 🕊 Create more freedom



1 Welcome!

From Overwhelmed to In Control

Same chaos. Different tomorrow!

How Getting Things Done (GTD) helps me – and can help you too.

2 Today's Journey

- ✓ What is GTD?
- ✓ The 5 steps
- ✓ Real examples
- ✓ My setup & tools
- ✓ Your turn
- ✓ Key takeaways

LESS CHAOS
MORE LIFE

3 Why GTD?

- ✓ Less mental stress
- ✓ Better focus
- ✓ Nothing falls through the cracks
- ✓ More time for what matters
- ✓ Works for work and personal life
- ✓ You can actually relax

A calmer mind.
A more intentional life.

4 What is GTD?

A simple, practical method to turn chaos into clarity.

"Your mind is for having ideas, not for holding them."
– David Allen

IDEAS
PLANS
ACTIONS
A CALMER YOU

5 The 5 Steps of GTD

1. **Capture** – Collect everything
2. **Clarify** – What is it? Next action?
3. **Organize** – Put it in the right place
4. **Review** – Look at it regularly
5. **Do** – Take action with confidence

Same steps. A brighter tomorrow.

6 Step 1: Capture

Get everything out of your head and into an inbox.

Ideas
Errands
Someday...

Empty your mind for what really matters.

INBOX

7 Step 2: Clarify

What is it? And what's the next action?

What's the next action?

- ✓ Is it actionable?
- ✓ What's the next step?
- ✓ Will it take < 2 minutes?
- ✓ Is it a project?
- ✓ Or maybe someday/later?

8 Step 3: Organize

Put it in the right place.

Right thing. Right place. Less chaos.

Next Actions
Projects
Someday Maybe
Reference

9 Step 4: Review

Look at it regularly.

A short review keeps everything on track.

WEEKLY REVIEW

GOOD PROGRESS

10 Step 5: Do

Take action with confidence.

Small steps make big progress!

- ✓ Focus
- ✓ Do the next action
- ✓ Check it off
- ✓ Feel good!

11 From Inbox to Next Actions

Let's take a real example.

Inbox items:

- Buy a birthday gift
- Plan summer vacation
- Fix the washing machine
- Call the bank
- Read that article
- ...

After clarifying:

- ✓ Buy birthday gift (Next Action)
- ✓ Research vacation (Next Action)
- ✓ Call bank (Next Action)
- ✓ Read article (Someday/Later)
- ...

12 Recurring Tasks

A simple daily/weekly table so I don't have to think "what should I do now?"

	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Morning routine	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Workout	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Check email	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
House tasks	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Family time	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Plan next day	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Decisions once. Less mental load every day.

13 My Personal Setup

GTD + ChatGPT

I use ChatGPT as my GTD assistant.

	/inbox	Add new items
List next actions	✓	✓
/done 6 30 min	✓	✓
/del 16	✓	✓
Break down this project	✓	✓
Suggest next action	✓	✓

Less admin. More action!

14 Real Examples

A few areas from my life.

Home
Work
Garden
Family
Health
Travel

15 Your Turn!

From your inbox to Next Actions.

YOUR IDEAS HERE

Let's work with some real examples together!

16 Try It Yourself

Start small. Real progress.

- Capture 10-15 items
- ✓ Find next actions
- ✓ Choose a simple system
- Do a daily review
- Take one action

You got this!

17 Tips for Success

What helps me (and might help you too).

- ✓ Keep it simple
- ✓ Be consistent, not perfect
- ✓ Use tools that work for you
- ✓ Focus on next actions
- ✓ Review regularly
- ✓ Celebrate progress

Progress over perfection.

18 Q&A

Questions? Ideas? Let's discuss!

19 Key Takeaways

GTD helps you:

- ✓ Clear your mind
- ✓ Focus on what matters
- ✓ Turn ideas into action
- ✓ Reduce stress
- ✓ Create more freedom

A CALMER MIND
A BRIGHTER TOMORROW

20 From Overwhelmed to In Control

Thank you!

GOOD THINGS HAPPEN

Same chaos. Different tomorrow!

Get things out of your head. Make the next action clear. Keep the system current. Then focus on what you choose to do.